AI IN HIGHER EDUCATION - WEEKLY BRIEF

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TO: Management Department Faculty, Isenberg School of Management
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RE: Weekly Brief - Oral Exams, Policy Drafts and an AI-Taught MBA (Vol. 38)

Executive Summary

Faculty at Chicago and USC are replacing take-home papers with oral exams, in-class writing and papers built from student conversations. At NYU Stern, two faculty members had a voice AI give oral final exams to 73 students over two semesters and had three AI models grade the transcripts, for less than a dollar an exam. In a national survey, most responding faculty said AI has weakened their confidence that student work is the student's own. University systems are writing rules in different ways: Alaska's regents postponed a statement of AI principles after faculty learned that Claude drafted the first version, Nebraska told employees to move university work to an enterprise ChatGPT account while leaving teaching decisions to faculty, and UIC requires instructors to tell students how they use AI in grading. A California university now sells a $10,000 online MBA taught by AI likenesses of its professors. Stanford is giving $10 million to departments that redesign whole majors, and a Stanford review of the research finds that AI helps learning more when students use it to understand material than when they use it to produce work. England's university regulator says many assessments will need to be AI-free.

Reading List

- **Chicago rethinks the take-home paper.** The Chicago Maroon reports on humanities Core faculty who now use in-class exams, discussion posts based on handwritten notes, and short papers that grow out of student conversations. [1]
- **USC tries 15-minute oral exams.** The Daily Trojan describes a computer scientist's one-on-one oral exams with standardized questions, and a writing professor's move to in-class tests. [2]
- **NYU Stern's voice-AI oral exam.** Panos Ipeirotis and Konstantinos Rizakos report in *Communications of the ACM* on an AI-run oral final and three-model grading in an undergraduate product-management course. The authors' version is free. [3, 4]
- **Faculty trust in student work.** An Inside Higher Ed and Hanover Research survey finds that nearly nine in ten respondents say AI has hurt their confidence that student work is authentic. [5]
- **Alaska postpones its AI statement.** The Anchorage Daily News reports that regents delayed "AI Engaged" to February after faculty objected that Claude wrote its first draft. [6, 7]

- **Nebraska standardizes on enterprise ChatGPT.** President Jeffrey Gold's message announces Executive Memorandum 48, which governs AI tools and data but leaves course rules to faculty. [8]
- **UIC asks faculty to disclose their own AI use.** UIC's AI Use and Disclosure Statement requires instructors to tell students how they plan to use AI in course design, grading and feedback. The policy dates from September; the coverage is new. [9, 10]
- **WVU adds an AI course attribute.** The Daily Athenaeum reports a Spring 2027 attribute for courses in which 20 percent of graded work concerns AI. The original page is gone; the link is to an archived copy. [11]
- **An MBA taught by AI avatars.** The Chronicle profiles San Francisco Bay University's $10,000 online MBA Pro+, in which AI likenesses of faculty deliver lectures. Paywalled. [12, 13, 14]
- **Stanford funds whole-major redesign.** Stanford's AI and Curricular Transformation grants offer departments $250,000 to $750,000 each from a $10 million fund. [15, 16]
- **What the research says so far.** Stanford's SCALE Initiative reviewed 52 causal studies of AI in education. The review is written for K-12 leaders. [17]
- **England calls for AI-free assessment.** The Office for Students will require assessments that reliably measure learning, which it says will often mean secure, AI-free assessment. [18]
- **AACSB counts new programs.** AACSB's 2026 State of Accreditation Report finds that analytics, data science and AI make up the largest share of new degree programs at member schools worldwide. [19]
- **UVA pays faculty AI guides.** The Cavalier Daily reports that 23 faculty guides, paid $5,500 each, are focusing this year on AI-free learning and curriculum-level change. [20]

Oral Exams Return, and a Business School Tries to Scale Them

At the University of Chicago, technology is now banned from humanities and social-sciences Core classrooms, even as the university gives every student access to Claude. Faculty are changing what they ask students to produce. Haitham Ibrahim added in-person midterm and final exams and now requires discussion posts to be based on notes students take on paper in class. Agnes Callard had replaced papers with in-class exams after ChatGPT appeared, but this year she lets students choose: three exams, or three short papers written after meeting with classmates to discuss the reading. "There are skills that students don't get to practice, don't get to learn if they don't have to do the kind of writing where you get to think about it for a little bit," she said. Bill Hutchison, who teaches the new first-year writing course, said, "One of the questions that AI raises is what kind of evidence of student thinking do we want to see." About 70 percent of first-years take that course this year, and it becomes required in 2027–28. [1]

At USC, which leaves AI decisions to departments and instructors, computer scientist Robin Jia gave oral exams for the first time this year: 15-minute one-on-one sessions on a standard set of questions. Elisa Warford, who teaches technical communication, switched to written tests after seeing a rise in "flawless" writing, while noting that students lose practice with longer writing. [2] Both campuses face the same cost. Exams written in class show who did the work, but students then get less practice at extended writing, and oral exams take a great deal of faculty time.

NYU Stern has tested one answer to the time problem. In an undergraduate course on AI/ML product management, Panos Ipeirotis and Konstantinos Rizakos used a voice AI built with ElevenLabs to give the final exam: an identity check, a defense of the student's own capstone project, and a discussion of a case. Students took it on webcam at any time within a nine-day window. Three models (Claude, Gemini and GPT-5) each scored the transcript on a five-part rubric, read the other two assessments and revised, and Claude produced the final grade and feedback. Across 36 students in Fall 2025 and 37 in Spring 2026, grading cost about 29 cents and 96 cents per exam, compared with an estimated $750 for human graders in the fall. Agreement among the three models rose after they reviewed one another's scores, from 0.52 to 0.86 on a standard 0-to-1 agreement measure in the fall. [3, 4]

Students were divided. In the fall, 70 percent agreed the exam "tested my actual understanding," but 83 percent found it more stressful than a written exam, and only 13 percent preferred an AI-run oral exam to other formats (25 percent in the spring). The authors are careful about what they can claim: "operational feasibility and promising reliability." Agreement among models shows that the models are consistent with one another, not that their grades match expert judgment, and the authors have not yet compared the grades against blind expert grading or checked for bias across student groups. [4]

Faculty Confidence in Student Work

Inside Higher Ed and Hanover Research surveyed faculty from September 21 to October 8; 1,665 of the 100,296 faculty invited responded. Half named the growing use of generative and agentic AI as a top concern about higher education, more than named federal interference (45 percent). Nearly nine in ten said AI has hurt their confidence that students' work or communications are authentic. Law and business faculty were the least likely to say so, at 82 percent. Sixty-seven percent said AI has hurt trust between them and their students, yet 53 percent said it has not changed their overall relationships with students, and 18 percent said it has improved their ability to give timely or individual support. Fewer than 2 percent of those invited responded, so the results may not represent all faculty, and they measure what faculty believe, not how much cheating occurs. [5]

Alaska and Nebraska: Two Ways to Write the Rules

The University of Alaska Board of Regents postponed its vote on "AI Engaged," a four-page statement of AI principles, until February. The document would require a system-wide AI policy within a year, require each of the three universities to write its own policy, and states that "UA will accelerate adoption." Chief information technology officer Ben Shier wrote the first draft by feeding Claude notes from regents, staff and presentations; he says about 20 percent of that draft survived the human edits that followed. According to the Anchorage Daily News, the use of AI was discussed internally but not attributed until October. Nearly 200 students and staff petitioned for a short statement written by people, and UAA's Faculty Senate postponed its own vote on a resolution to reject and replace the document. Philosophy professor Joel Potter argued that whether AI may help write university plans "needs to be a matter of thoughtful debate, rather than a foregone conclusion." President Matthew Cooper said, "we're never going to have everyone on the same page with AI." In the meantime, regents directed an AI coordinating council to begin campus policies. [6, 7]

The University of Nebraska took a narrower route. Executive Memorandum 48 governs tools and data, not teaching. Faculty and staff who complete a security training receive an enterprise ChatGPT account, and those who use free or personally paid accounts for university work must move to the enterprise account by the end of the fall semester. A new governance group that includes instructional faculty will decide which tools are approved and how AI use should be disclosed. President Gold wrote that "EM 48 does not determine whether AI should be used in teaching or research. Faculty retain the authority to establish expectations for AI use in their courses." [8]

UIC's statement shows a third approach. Syllabi must state what AI use is allowed for students, and faculty "must also disclose any planned use of AI tools in course design, instructional materials, assessment, grading support, feedback generation, or other teaching-related activities." [9] The page does not give an effective date; its metadata indicate it was posted in September.

An MBA Taught by AI Likenesses of Faculty

San Francisco Bay University in Fremont, California, launched MBA Pro+ in July: 12 online courses for $10,000. [13] According to The Chronicle, AI avatars of real faculty deliver the lectures, an AI tutor called Bayley answers questions between sessions, and the university has spent close to $2 million on the program, which had 27 students as of early November. Faculty cannot earn tenure and are asked to grant rights to their name, image and likeness in perpetuity for an up-front payment; three business faculty declined. [12] The university is accredited by the WASC Senior College and University Commission, most recently in June 2026, and does not distribute federal financial aid. [14] The Chronicle article is paywalled; we read an archived copy.

Stanford: Money for Majors, and a Review of the Evidence

Stanford announced on November 3 a $10 million program of grants to departments, not individual instructors. From Winter 2027, departments that offer undergraduate majors may apply each quarter for $250,000 to $750,000 for one- to two-year projects, and Stanford expects to fund 15 or more. Every project must map learning outcomes across the major. Eligible changes include "teaching and assessing learning without AI (e.g., oral assessments, in-class learning activities)" as well as integrating AI. The money pays for faculty and staff time, not travel. [15, 16]

A week later, Stanford's SCALE Initiative updated its review of rigorous research on AI in education. The number of causal studies grew from 20 to 52. Its main finding: "AI appears more likely to support learning when students use it to understand new material than when they use it to produce work for them, although neither type of use consistently improves learning." Students often reported better experiences with AI that did not show up in learning outcomes, and one study found that teachers' use of an AI support tool reduced students' motivation and confidence. [17] The review is framed for K-12 schools, so faculty should treat it as general evidence about learning, not as a study of college courses.

England's Regulator Asks for AI-Free Assessment

England's Office for Students said on November 11 that it will require universities to ensure assessments "are valid and reliable measures of students' knowledge and skills," and that "in many cases, this will require the use of secure (AI-free) assessments." Its research found that students described peers who completed assessments with AI "sometimes in just a few minutes" and earned similar grades. The regulator lists conditions of registration, fines and suspension of funding among its enforcement tools. [18] The policy does not apply to U.S. universities, but it is the first national regulator we have seen tie AI-resistant assessment to enforcement.

What This Means for Isenberg

The NYU Stern study matters most to us. It comes from a business school, it addresses both the problem we described in Vol. 37 (unsupervised work no longer shows who did the thinking) and the time-consuming nature of oral exams, and it reports real costs and student reactions. A colleague considering oral defenses of case analyses or Capstone decisions could begin with human-run orals for a sample of students. If AI grading is tried, the instructor should stay responsible for the grade, since the authors do not claim their AI grades match expert judgment. Chicago's conversation-based papers offer a way to keep extended writing while gathering more evidence of the student's own thinking. UIC's rule is also worth considering voluntarily: if we expect students to disclose AI use, a syllabus line describing our own use in grading and feedback costs little. Finally, SFBU's $10,000 MBA and AACSB's count of new AI programs show that competition for business students now includes AI-delivered degrees, and our programs should be able to say clearly what in-person teaching adds.

Notes and Sources

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2. *Daily Trojan*. "Students, Faculty Diverge on AI Approaches in Higher Education." November 5, 2026. Byline not captured in extracted text. Faculty testimony.
3. Ipeirotis, Panos, and Konstantinos Rizakos. "Scalable and Personalized Oral Assessments Using Voice AI." *Communications of the ACM*, 2026. DOI 10.1145/3831714. The ACM page blocked our access; facts are taken from [4].
4. Ipeirotis, Panos, and Konstantinos Rizakos. "Scalable and Personalized Oral Assessments Using Voice AI." arXiv:2603.18221v3, July 26, 2026. Authors' version of [3]. Two cohorts in one course; reliability among AI graders, not validity against expert grading.
5. Whitford, Emma. "Faculty Report Self-Censoring on DEI, Politics." *Inside Higher Ed*, November 2, 2026. Survey with Hanover Research, September 21–October 8; 1,665 responses from 100,296 invitations. Measures perceptions, not misconduct.
6. *Anchorage Daily News*. "UA Faculty Clash Over Postponed Artificial Intelligence Guidelines." November 11, 2026. Byline not captured in extracted text.

7. University of Alaska. "UA eNews, November 6, 2026." Office of Public Affairs. Regents' meeting summary. The AI Engaged document itself was not reviewed.

8. Gold, Jeffrey P. "A Message from President Gold on New AI Guidelines." University of Nebraska System, posted by UNO November 5, 2026 (sent November 4). The text of Executive Memorandum 48 was not reviewed.

9. University of Illinois Chicago, Office of the Vice Provost for Faculty Affairs. "Artificial Intelligence (AI) Use and Disclosure Statement." No effective date stated; page metadata show September 8, 2026.

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14. WASC Senior College and University Commission. "San Francisco Bay University." Institution directory, accessed November 12, 2026.

15. Stanford Center for Teaching and Learning. "AI and Curricular Transformation at Stanford." Grant program page, accessed November 12, 2026.

16. *Stanford Report*. "Stanford Invests $10 Million to Rethink Majors for the AI Age." November 3, 2026. The page blocked our access; cited for the announcement date only.

17. Walker, Seth, Lily Fesler, JP Martinez Claeys, Chris Agnew, and Susanna Loeb. "The Evidence Base on AI in K-12: A November 2026 Review." SCALE Initiative, Stanford University, November 2026. Covers studies published October 2025–June 2026; framed for K-12.

18. Office for Students. "Universities Should Help Students Develop AI Skills While Protecting Confidence in Degrees." November 11, 2026. England only.

19. AACSB International. "2026 State of Accreditation Report." October 19, 2026. Analytics, data science and AI were 19 percent of 3,021 new programs described by 718 schools over five years (28 percent including information systems). Global data, not U.S. only.

20. Gabriel, Charlotte. "Faculty AI Guides Program to Explore How AI Will Shape Education." *The Cavalier Daily*, November 9, 2026.

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